



JYOTI KAPOOR

Mueenuddin is the newest Pakistani star

When he's rich and powerful, a poor driver whose wife he covets, implores him, "Please, Chaudrey Sahib, you and I grew up together in Dunyapur, we played together as children. I beg you, don't take what's mine. You have so much, and I so little." Jaglani answers, "I have so much because I took what I wanted. Go away."

The loose movement of power, and the casual violence that goes with it, emerges as not just another thread, but as the only law governing this world. It can make the society, 'of feudal Pakistan', feel enclosed, inaccessible to the outsider. Some years ago, I experienced it first-hand on the lands of a young Sindhi feudal called the Mango King. I wrote then, "Though occasionally I felt his pain, I didn't understand his world; I didn't think it was a world that could be made understandable to someone who wasn't obliged to work by its arbitrary laws; its brutalities were its own." Make no mistake, Daniyal Mueenuddin is the biggest talent to come out of the brief literary flowering of English writing in Pakistan; and yet, it was with an old feeling of detachment, after some initial distress, that I left the painful world of these stories. ■

The Madhouse

Yet another story of a quest for roots that leads nowhere

| By Sonya Dutta Choudhury |



DAMAGE
by AMRITA KUMAR
HarperCollins
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Four sisters squabble over a tiny mosquito-ridden house. It's a small, dysfunctional house, and it hasn't had a very happy history. Mad matriarch Beatrice and youngest daughter Gudda live here. Elder sisters Aditi, Sujata and Malini have been driven away, years ago, by mother playing host to motley missionaries and dope dealing evangelists. Gudda stays behind, making nimbu pani for

missionaries. Even when she escapes, to a job in media and then to marriage, she's soon back. Divorced and unemployed.

The house is full of strange occupants. There's Vylit, a kleptomaniac creature from nowhere and Beatrice's recently rediscovered eccentric sister Flora. But Gudda tolerates all this awfulness.

Grand you might say, even King Lear-ish, this saga of sibling spats. But publishing executive-turned-author Amrita Kumar's debut novel has whinging long-windedness about it. Gudda is no Cordelia. And Beatrice, bless her senile soul, is certainly no King Lear. The most enduring image of this matriarch, who dominates Gudda's life and times, is from a clothesline on page 4, of "old maid-enform bras, lifeless, stained champagne at the armpits, and her hibiscus nighties with frills". Underclothes (or lack of them) continue to be a leit-motif in this story. There are those of Pilar the missionary, conspicuous by their absence. And those of Beatrice, as a little girl, growing up with a guardian who believed knickers 'were an unhealthy English habit, that airing your private parts set your soul free'.

The other thread of the book is Gudda's frenzied foraging for her roots. She searches. For her ancestral village, and for her ancestral house. Such a quest, the stuff of many glorious stories, may bring with it (you hope) the promise of local colour and conflict. The reader joins the general gaggle of people in the book who do nothing but wait for Beatrice to die. Not a very nice place to be in. ■